
Paper 3, Option 35.2:

The British experience of warfare, c1790–1918

Overview

This option comprises two parts: the *Aspects in breadth* focus on long-term changes and contextualise the *Aspects in depth*, which focus in detail on key episodes.

Together, the breadth and depth topics explore the British experience of war in different aspects of major overseas conflicts and the changing relationship between the state and the people as the government attempted to create an effective fighting machine and prepare the people for war. Within the primarily military focus on the experience of warfare, this option also gives students the opportunity to explore its political, social and economic dimensions and their part in generating pressure for change.

Aspects in breadth: the changing role of government in preparing the nation for war, c1790–1918	
Themes	Content
1 Changes in organising the military	• The military and reasons for changes 1790-1918: improvements to army organisation, ordnance and supplies (key developments: McNeill-Tulloch Report 1855, Cardwell's army reforms 1868-74, Haldane's army reforms 1905-12). The navy and changes in organisation: decommissioning ships and reduction in the size of the navy after 1815; the significance of the shift from sail to steam; government reforms (key developments: Graham's reforms 1832, Fisher's reforms at the Admiralty 1904-10). • The recruitment of the fighting forces 1790-1918: impressment, volunteers and conscripts (key development: conscription 1916).
2 Changes in weaponry and the role of the people	• Changing weaponry 1790-1918: the role of science and technology in improving weaponry (key developments: carronades and the navy in the 1790s, Congreve's rockets 1806, William Armstrong's new artillery 1859-60, the Vickers machine gun 1914-18, development of the tank 1915-18). • The populace and the war effort 1790-1918: providing finance – taxation, bonds, consols and war loans; changing civilian roles, from camp followers to an organised home front.

Aspects in depth: Britain at war overseas	
Key topics	Content
1 Britain and the French Wars, 1793–1815	• Facing the French threat on land: the role of Wellington in the defeat of the French. • Facing the French threat at sea: the role of Nelson in the defeat of the French. • The impact on the British economy, industry, commerce and agriculture of the length of the conflict.
2 The Crimean War, 1854–56	• Facing the Russian threat in the Crimea: the impact of the battles of Alma and Balaclava and the siege of Sebastopol; the role of Lord Raglan. • The problems of medical care; the work of Florence Nightingale and Mary Seacole in the Crimea. • Changing attitudes of the public in Britain to the conduct of the war, including the impact of the photography of Roger Fenton and the reportage of William Russell.
3 The second Boer War, 1899–1902	• Facing the Boers in southern Africa: the nature of British army; the significance of the sieges of Mafeking, Kimberley and Ladysmith and the impact of Black Week. • The importance of the roles of Field Marshalls Roberts and Kitchener, and General Sir Redvers Buller in achieving victory. • Changing attitudes of the public in Britain to the conflict, including the impact of the reportage of Winston Churchill and the work of Emily Hobhouse.
4 Trench warfare on the Western Front, 1914–18	• Reasons for change from a war of movement to attrition; entrenchment and the building of defensive systems; the need for military adjustment; the use of new fighting techniques and new technology – machine guns, chlorine gas, tanks, fuse 106 and the creeping barrage. • British public perception of, and changing attitudes to, war on the Western Front; government attempts to restrict, direct reportage by journalists from the Western Front. • The significance of Haig's major offensives for the conduct of the war and attitudes to it: the Somme in 1916, Passchendaele in 1917, the Hundred Days' Offensive in 1918.
5 The war in the air, 1914–18	• The impact of aerial reconnaissance: photographic, observation and communication. • The development of the Royal Flying Corps as a fighting force; the importance of technology in the development of air combat; the importance of air power in achieving victory in 1918. • The impact on public opinion, propaganda and defence systems of Zeppelin and Gotha bombing of undefended British towns.